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TRIBUTE

VIRAT IS THE MOST INFLUENTIAL CRICKETER OF THE LAST DECADE

From Sunil Gavaskar to Sachin Tendulkar, I have not encountered a cricketer with such a **fierce desire** to play the game.



RAVISHASTRI

Knowing Virat Kohli has been a great privilege. I saw him grow, not just as a cricketer, but as a force of nature. From a fiery young talent to the colossus who came to define an era, he rose not by chance, but through an almost obsessive devotion to his craft. It was his punishing hard work that drove him to the summit.

And with him, he lifted Indian

cricket, transforming it into a powerhouse, feared and respected, the most formidable team on the planet. Being part of this team built by Virat will remain special to my heart.

From Sunil Gavaskar to Sachin Tendulkar, I have not encountered a cricketer with such a fierce desire to play the game. He wanted to own it and did that with his unbridled passion and energy. He had the rare ability to stare down his opponent, seize control of the battle, and bend its rhythm to his will — a quality that placed Virat in a league of his own.

How do I look at Virat? An individual who had no challenge. A leader who cracked the whip to extract the best out of his team. A great ambassador for Test cricket when the format was losing out to the explosion of T20 cricket. True,

T20 brings in the moolah, but Virat brought the fans to the Test arenas, at home and overseas.

Tendulkar's magical knocks drew cricket lovers from all over the world. Virat, too, achieved that status on the strength of his stupendous passion and talent, which he kept honing by accepting his role as the greatest ambassador for red-ball cricket.

To me, he is also the greatest red-ball captain ever. Forty wins in 68 Tests as captain places him in a rare category.

He was a man who loved to be in the thick of action. The camera would pick him in different acts — as a fielder, batsman, taking fantastic catches, inflicting incredible run-outs. You couldn't take him out of the game — he wouldn't let you.

At the fall of every wicket, he was the first to reach the bowler, roaring,